E · PERSONAL GROWTH & BEHAVIORAL PATTERNS

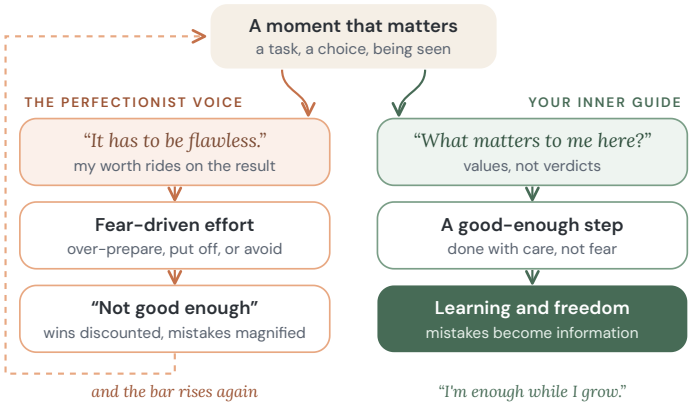
# Perfectionism & Fear of Failure

Draws on cognitive behavioral models of perfectionism, Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT), and self-compassion research

## 1 WHAT IS IT?

Perfectionism is more than high standards. It's the belief that your worth depends on getting things exactly right, with harsh self-judgment when you don't. Healthy striving pulls you toward what you care about; perfectionism pushes you away from what you fear, and can drown out your inner sense of what matters.

## 2 HOW DOES IT WORK?




An original illustration. Most people move between both voices; the aim is to notice which one is steering.

## 3 WHY DOES IT HAPPEN?

Perfectionism often begins as protection. If love or belonging seemed to depend on achievement, being flawless became a way to stay safe. Research separates high standards from perfectionistic concerns (fear of mistakes, worry about judgment, self-criticism); the concerns are most linked to anxiety, depression, and burnout.

The standard keeps moving: wins get discounted, mistakes feel like proof of inadequacy, and the bar rises. Choices come from "How do I avoid failing?" instead of "What matters to me?", and the inner guide grows quiet.

**Normal or a concern?** Caring about quality is healthy. Perfectionism becomes a concern when it fuels ongoing anxiety, procrastination, burnout, or strained relationships. It responds well to therapy.

## 4 WHAT CAN HELP?

### Name the perfectionist voice

When "it has to be perfect" shows up, notice it: "There's the perfectionist part." Stepping back from the thought gives you room to choose.

### Ask your inner guide

Trade "What would be flawless?" for "What matters to me here, and what's a good-enough step toward it?" Values give direction without demanding perfection.

### Practice good enough

Try small experiments: send the email after one review, set a time limit, share a draft. Notice what happens, and meet discomfort with kindness.

## 5 REFLECTION QUESTION

*If you trusted that you were already enough, what would you do differently this week?*

## 6 KEY TAKEAWAY

You were never meant to be flawless, only true to what matters to you.

## 7 REFERENCES


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